

consistent screen, corner-to-corner. The reverse video contrast test did not pose problems for any of the 17-inch monitors.

Passmark Monitor Test

We used the LCD pixel persistence test in the Passmark monitor test to check for the pixel persistence problem with the panels. In this test, a bright white block moves at various speeds across the monitor, ranging from 100 pixels/second to 800 pixels/second.

The entire set of monitors in both categories failed to display even the slowest moving block without persistence—all of them scored very low.



Acer AL1714sm

CMV CT-712A

Our test results lead us to believe that none of the LCDs we tested are at a stage where they could be considered good for games or movies. If you're into gaming, you're better off with a CRT. If you want to watch movies on an LCD panel, don't expect an exceptional viewing experience.

Viewable Angle Test

Here, we used a text screen in DisplayMate, and a movie scene, to find the maximum viewing angle of each monitor. In the 15-inch category, the HCL HCM 510LSA had the smallest viewing angle in text and movie mode—137 and 122 degrees respectively.

Most panels returned a higher viewing angle in text mode—this was because of the bright background. They suffered in the movie test because the movie was a mix of bright outdoors and dimly-lit indoors scenes. The ViewSonic VE510b reached 140 degrees in the movie, which was highest we saw in the 15-inch category.

In the 17-inch segment, the Philips 170s managed only 127 degrees in the text test, whereas the CMV, HCL and LG returned 132 degrees in the movie test. The BenQ FP783 and the Philips 170S managed 148 degrees, which was the highest we saw.

Cost

The Acer AL1512 carries a price tag of Rs 9,999 excluding taxes, whereas the 17-inch Acer is available for as low as Rs 14,999, which makes it cheaper than some of the 15-inch models. There are still brands such as NEC, which sell at a premium—Rs 22,500 for the 15-inch model, which is about Rs 5,000 more than other well-known brands such as Philips, ViewSonic and BenQ.

And The Winner Is...

If you take into consideration just pure performance, the 15-inch BenQ FP537s comes out tops. A worthy mention where performance is concerned is the ViewSonic VE510b. But neither of these monitors could make it to the top because of their price tags.

Price played an important role

in deciding our Gold winner, which is the Acer AL1512. It fared comparatively well in both performance and features, but its really low price—just Rs 9,999—helped it edge pass models that performed equally well. The CMV CT-529A, which is our Silver winner, returned features and performance scores similar to the Acer, but is slightly higher priced.

In the 17-inch category again, price played a major role in deciding our winner, and the Acer AL1714sm, with a price tag of just Rs 14,999, won Gold.

Most of the other monitors had similar features and performance scores, but are priced very differently. The Acer, which is the cheapest 17-inch model, retails for just Rs 14,999. This makes it cheaper than many 15-inch models, whereas the NEC 1770NXM is priced at a whopping Rs 39,500. The kind of performance that the NEC 1770NXM and the BenQ FP783 gave was similar to that of less expensive models from other brands, and at the same time, they did not carry features that could justify the high prices.

The Silver winner in the 17-inch category is the CMV CT-712A, which is very competitively priced at Rs 17,000.

To Buy Or Not To Buy...

LCDs have their pluses and their minuses. We've mentioned the main pluses. And they have their cons too—movies and games are CRT territory.

One reason LCDs are not suitable for games is that they're fixed resolution—so you end up either playing your game in a small window, or with all the action blurred. The fixed resolution can be a problem in other areas as well. As for movies, it depends. Some of us really will not find fault with the way movies look on an LCD; some of us will.

Whether to go in for an LCD monitor is something to think about for a while. LCDs look good, have flaunt value, and the image, in general, is crisper than that on a CRT. For popularity to grow, however, costs have to come down, the nitty-gritties that persist have to fade away and the user needs to know that this makes the best sense—for business or pleasure. So, are you ready to go slim? ☐

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